

Reforms to the Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act

The Australian Government has made reforms to the Environment Protection and Biodiversity Conservation Act 1999 (EPBC Act). These reforms will apply to Regional Forest Agreements (RFAs).

The new laws will remove the current exemption to the EPBC Act for RFA forestry operations. From 1 July 2027, RFA forestry operations will need to comply with the same rules and standards as other industries. Relevant states, industry and other stakeholders will be consulted as implementation progresses.

National Environmental Standards are currently under development and consultation will be undertaken on the Standards as they are developed. [More information on the Standards and consultation process](#) can be found at the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water consultation hub.

The Australian Government will work closely with the RFA state governments to support them to demonstrate their regulatory systems for forestry meet these requirements and to gain suitable approvals under the EPBC Act for RFA forestry operations.

[More information on the EPBC Act reforms and approval pathways](#) are available at the Department of Climate Change, Energy, the Environment and Water website.

Regional Forest Agreements (RFAs) are long-term plans for the sustainable management and conservation of Australia's native forests. There are five RFAs in three states: three in New South Wales and one each in Western Australia and Tasmania. The five Victorian RFAs were terminated on 31 December 2024, following the Victorian Government's decision to cease native forestry in that state.

The RFAs seek to balance economic, social and environmental demands on forests by setting obligations and commitments for forest management that deliver:

- certainty of resource access and supply to industry – building investment confidence
- ecologically sustainable forest management – ensuring forests are appropriately managed and regenerated
- an expanded and permanent forest conservation estate – to provide for the protection of Australia's unique forest biodiversity.

The RFAs result from scientific study, consultation and negotiation covering a diverse range of interests. Our website contains a number of historical publications that demonstrate the detailed scientific, economic and social processes that underpinned the development of each RFA.

For details on how each of the five RFAs have been implemented by the states, see the [relevant state forestry website](#).